



A YouBike dock at Xindian Station — one bike per post, 2.0's signature change from 1.0's two.

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YouBike

Taipei's bike-share ran three fare policies and two mutually incompatible dock generations before this page's writing, and the story English coverage tells — "free rides for transferring since 2018" — turns out to be the middle third of a longer, better-documented arc.

"The first thirty minutes are free if you are transferring from the metro" is the version of YouBike most visitors hear, and it describes one six-year window in the system's life rather than the whole of it — and not even the current window^[15] ^[14]. The fuller story, drawn from the city's own press

releases and Taiwanese reporting, is a public bicycle system that has run three different fare policies and two mutually incompatible generations of hardware, in place, without ever closing.

YOUBIKE			
OPERATOR 微笑單車股份有限公司 (Smile Bike Co., Ltd.), under contract to Taipei City Government ^[10]	PILOT BEGAN 11 March 2009, Xinyi District ^[1]	CITYWIDE 1.0 OPERATION 30 August 2012 ^[1]	2.0 TRIAL BEGAN 15 January 2020, Gongguan / NTU ^[2]
2.0 FULL SERVICE 8 May 2021, 10:20 ^[5]	1.0 RETIRED IN TAIPEI 3 December 2022, 00:00 ^[7]	2.0E LAUNCHED 30 August 2024, Taipei and New Taipei ^[13]	

A BOT scheme that started with eleven stations

Taipei's public bicycle system began as a build–operate–transfer contract let to Giant under then-mayor Hao Lung-pin, piloted in Xinyi District from 11 March 2009^[1] ^[20]. Citywide operation started on 30 August 2012, and by the time that initial trial period ended on 30 November 2012 the system had already passed one million cumulative rides^[1].

Free, then not free, then free for some, then free again

This is the part almost nobody outside Taiwan gets right, because most accounts freeze on whichever policy was current when they were written.

The system launched with the first 30 minutes free, and stayed that way until 1 April 2015^[18]^[17]. Mayor Ko Wen-je's administration then introduced a flat NT\$5 charge for that first half-hour, arguing the free period was subsidising recreational riding rather than commuting^[17]. New Taipei, whose own network was still under construction, pointedly did not follow — it kept its first 30 minutes free through the rest of 2015, budgeting roughly NT\$70 million a year to do so^[18]. What the 2015 change actually saved Taipei's budget is itself disputed: one account puts the monthly subsidy fall at NT\$20 million to NT\$8 million, another at NT\$20 million to NT\$13 million^[17] ^[18] — the same policy, two different numbers, neither resolved here.

A narrower discount followed in 2018: NT\$5 off when transferring to or from a bus or the MRT, rather than a free period for everyone^[15]. This is the version of the story that made it into English coverage, and as a snapshot of 2018–2024 it isn't wrong — it is just not the whole arc,

and it stopped being current on **28 February 2024**, when Mayor Chiang Wan-an restored an unconditional first-30-minutes-free policy for registered members citywide and the transfer discount was cancelled the same day, since a universal free period made a transfer-specific one redundant^[14] ^[15]. The city projected a 15% ridership increase and about 7,000 tonnes a year of avoided carbon emissions^[16]. Ride a YouBike 2.0 in Taipei today and, if you are a registered member, that first half hour costs nothing regardless of where you are coming from; beyond it, the standard rate runs NT\$10 per 30 minutes for up to four hours, NT\$20 to eight hours, and NT\$40 beyond^[14].

Why there is a 2.0 at all

The generational split is a genuinely engineering-driven story, and the city's own documents say so plainly. YouBike 1.0's docks needed a municipal power connection: the station-siting standard the transport department published on 23 March 2015 required, alongside a roughly 600-metre spacing principle and a minimum 2-metre clear sidewalk width, that a station sit near an existing power supply^[6]. That single requirement — road excavation, a utility connection, a minimum viable scale to justify it — was what capped how fast and how densely the network could grow^[4].

YouBike 2.0's answer was to move the intelligence off the dock and onto the bicycle. In the transport department's own words, the redesign 「免除市電需求，控制器移轉車機」 — removes the need for mains power and shifts the controller onto the bike itself^[4] — which let station siting respond to terrain and sidewalk width instead of utility access^[4]. The physical dock changed too: 1.0 parked two bikes per post, 2.0 parks one^[5]. The trade was a lighter, cheaper, more flexible dock for total incompatibility with the existing fleet — a 1.0 card or bike could not use a 2.0 station, or vice versa, from the day the trial began.

That trial started at 10:00 on 15 January 2020, around Gongguan [\[/rail/metro/stations/g07/\]](/rail/metro/stations/g07/) MRT Station and National Taiwan University: 102 stations sharing about 1,800 docks, and 500 new bicycles, according to the launch announcement^[2]. A follow-up release one month later, describing what reads as the same pilot area, instead gives 600 new bicycles^[3] — a discrepancy between two official releases six weeks apart that neither states an explanation for and that this page does not attempt to resolve. Full service across Taipei began at 10:20 on 8 May 2021: 160 new stations that day on top of the existing 103 in Gongguan and around NTU, for 263 total, with a year-end target of 750 stations and new batches of stations activated every Tuesday and Friday^[5]. New Taipei's own 2.0 network reached full service on 20 October 2021^[1].

Retiring 1.0

By October 2022, YouBike 2.0 had already reached its 1,200-station citywide target, and 1.0 — the system that had carried Taipei's bike-share for thirteen years — accounted for just 8.5% of rides, turning over 1.8 times a day per bike^[7]. Taipei switched it off entirely at 00:00 on 3 December 2022, after more than 200 million cumulative rides^[7]. New Taipei kept its own 1.0 fleet running for a while longer, and the mismatch produced a real inconvenience at the

boundary: a rider who picked up an orange 1.0 bike in New Taipei and carried it into Taipei after the cutover faced a NT\$350 fee to have it collected, because there was nowhere in the city left to return it to^[19].

Retired 1.0 bicycles went three ways. The city transferred 1,106 to its own agencies, for neighbourhood patrols and school cycling-safety education, and donated 1,300 to Indigenous communities (原鄉)^[8], marking the retirement with a memorial installation at MRT Taipei City Hall [\[/rail/metro/stations/bl18/\]](/rail/metro/stations/bl18/) Station Exit 3 — the system's very first station^[8]. Bicycles judged beyond further use were sold to a recycling contractor in late 2021 at NT\$41 each; the city's own clarification states this reflects the cost of disassembly, transport, labour and disposal rather than an underpriced sale of public property^[9]. That NT\$41 is a scrap value, not a replacement cost, and this page does not have a sourced figure for what an original YouBike 1.0 actually cost the city to buy — a NT\$10,000 figure has circulated but was not found in any source this run, and Chinese Wikipedia's NT\$13,000 carries no citation of its own^[20].

Electric assist, and where things stand

YouBike 2.0E — the electric-assist version — launched simultaneously in Taipei and New Taipei on 30 August 2024, giving a stated 80 to 100 km of range on a full charge on flat ground, with no free period or subsidy: a flat NT\$20 per 30 minutes for the first two hours, NT\$40 beyond, on the same docks and app as standard 2.0^[13]. It does not get the first-30-minutes-free benefit or the TPASS [\[/ticketing/guides/cards-passes-and-fares/\]](/ticketing/guides/cards-passes-and-fares/) 基北北桃1200 discount that standard 2.0 carries in Taipei, with a carve-out only for holders of Taipei-issued senior or disability transit cards^[12] — a distinction easy to miss if a source treats "YouBike" as one undifferentiated product.

As of a Taipei transport department release dated 14 August 2025, the city was operating 1,633 stations and 23,860 bikes, including 2,000 e-assist models, and was closing in on 400 million cumulative Taipei rides^[11]. That milestone came fast: 100 million to 200 million took about three and a half years, 200 million to 300 million took two and a half, and 300 million to 400 million took seventeen months — entirely inside the window opened by the February 2024 fare change^[11]. Across every Taiwanese city YouBike operates in, cumulative rides passed one billion on 4 June 2025^[1]. The same August 2025 release names a 2026 target of 2,000 stations and 4,500 2.0E bikes specifically^[11] — narrower than the 27,500-bike, 2,000-station citywide target officials gave in February 2024 reporting^[15] ^[16]. Their relationship remains TBC: the 4,500-bike target could be an e-assist subset of a still-current 27,500 total, or the plan could have changed, but nothing found restates the larger figure alongside the newer one.

Static station snapshot

A full TDX Bike Station/City pull retrieved on 23 August 2026 returned 1,794 Taipei station rows with a published capacity total of 50,877 docks^[21]. The same pull returned 1,593 New Taipei rows and 48,355 published docks^[21]. Taoyuan returned 699 rows and 24,214 published docks^[21].

Those three municipalities therefore contribute 4,086 static station rows in this dated build snapshot^[21]. An earlier direct check recorded 1,790 Taipei rows, 1,593 New Taipei rows and 698 Taoyuan rows, for 4,081 in total; that is a dated retrieval conflict, not a reason to average the values^[21].

The TDX Station/City records supply names, addresses, coordinates and published capacity, while current available bikes and return docks belong to a separate live availability feed and are not treated as static page facts^[21]. This first layer covers Taipei, New Taipei and Taoyuan; other TPASS-zone municipalities remain outside the committed pull^[21].

The 1,633 Taipei stations reported by the transport department on 14 August 2025 remain a separate dated official figure^[11]. It measures a different time and publication scope from the 1,794-row TDX snapshot and is kept as a conflict rather than rewritten as a growth rate^[11]^[21].

Open evidence

- **1.0's exact fleet size at Taipei's retirement.** Chinese Wikipedia gives 13,072 bikes; no primary figure for the fleet at the 3 December 2022 cutover was found this run, so the specs table above marks it TBC^[20].
- **The operator's ownership structure.** 微笑單車股份有限公司 runs the system under contract to Taipei's transport department^[10]; its organisational relationship to Giant, and the systems-design firm reported to have built the electronics, were not independently confirmed against a primary source this run.
- **The 2018–19 New Taipei "E-YouBike" trial and the Putian, China variant** that reportedly reuses retired YouBike 1.0 docks. Both appear only in Chinese Wikipedia here, and no primary New Taipei or Giant/Kunshan source for either was located in the time available^[20].
- **A primary source for the NT\$350 cross-boundary fee.** It rests on one secondary account^[19].
- **Contract and renewal terms** between Taipei City Government and Smile Bike Co. — nothing found this run addresses them.

References

15 of 21 sources on this page are primary — published by the operator, the builder or government.

- 1 **YouBike — About YouBike — Milestones** [<https://www.youbike.com.tw/region/main/about-youbike/milestones/>]
YouBike微笑單車—認識YouBike—大事記
PRIMARY 微笑單車股份有限公司 (Smile Bike Co., Ltd.) accessed 2026-08-12
The operator's own dated milestone list. Source for the 11 March 2009 pilot date, the 30 August 2012 citywide start, the 30 November 2012 one-million-ride mark, New Taipei's 20 October 2021 full 2.0 launch, the 30 August 2024 2.0E launch (cross-checked against YouBike's own service announcement), and the 4 June 2025 one-billion-ride milestone: 「2025-06-04：總騎乘次數突破十億人次」.

- 2 **Press release — YouBike 2.0 trial scheme launches** [https://dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=D739A9F6B5C0AB95&s=3AA4E1B03774D828]
臺北市府交通局-新聞稿-YouBike 2.0試辦計畫啟動
PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation (臺北市府交通局) accessed 2026-08-12
The trial-launch announcement: 15 January 2020, 10:00, Gongguan/NTU, 102 stations sharing about 1,800 docks, 500 new bicycles, and the design shift to a bike-mounted control unit and lightweight dock — incompatible with 1.0 equipment from day one.

- 3 **Press release — YouBike 2.0's usage rate is good, come try it** [https://www.dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=D739A9F6B5C0AB95&s=D26B7F6E75FFA89F]
臺北市府交通局-新聞稿-YouBike 2.0使用率佳，歡迎共同體驗
PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12
One month into the trial: over 150,000 rides, average 8+ turnovers/bike/day, and — set against the trial-launch release above — 600 new bicycles rather than 500 for what reads as the same pilot area. The unresolved conflict between the two releases on this page.

- 4 **Press release — the Taipei YouBike 2.0 plan explained** [https://www.dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=D739A9F6B5C0AB95&s=52E5A3028A0A021C&sms=72544237BBE4C5F6]
臺北市府交通局-新聞稿-臺北市YouBike2.0計畫說明
PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12
The city's own stated rationale for the redesign: 1.0 needed a mains power connection and a minimum viable scale, both capping expansion; 2.0 「免除市電需求，控制器移轉車機」 — removes the mains requirement, moves the controller onto the bike — letting siting respond to terrain and sidewalk width instead.

- 5 **Press release — YouBike 2.0 goes into full service, today** [https://www.dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=D739A9F6B5C0AB95&sms=72544237BBE4C5F6&s=8BB189B8A06408F0]
臺北市府交通局-新聞稿-YouBike 2.0 正式營運就是今天 騎向更便利的明天
PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12
8 May 2021, 10:20: 160 new stations added on top of the 103 existing Gongguan/NTU stations (263 total), year-end target 750 stations, and the dock comparison — 2.0 is one bike per post (1柱1車) against 1.0's two (1柱2車).

- 6 **Press release — YouBike now has station-siting standards, one consistent set of criteria** [<https://dot.gov.taipei/ct.asp?xItem=100112484&ctNode=12308&mp=117001>]

PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12

23 March 2015. The 1.0-era siting rules: ≥600 m station spacing, ≥2 m clear sidewalk width or ≥6 m clearance off it, a 30 m/15-dock minimum footprint, school approval near primary schools — and explicitly, a nearby power supply. The clause 2.0 was built to remove.

- 7 **Press release — Taipei's YouBike 1.0 system to retire fully, stopping operation 00:00, 3 December (Saturday)** [https://dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=D739A9F6B5C0AB95&sms=72544237BBE4C5F6&s=A310D64F8712A15D]

臺北市府交通局-新聞稿-臺北市YouBike1.0系統將全面退場 111年12月3日（星期六）0時起停止營運

PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12

The retirement announcement: 2.0 had already hit its 1,200-station citywide target by October 2022, 1.0 was down to 8.5% of ridership with a 1.8 turnover, and the system closed for good at 00:00 on 3 December 2022 after 13+ years and 200 million-plus rides.

- 8 **Press release — Taipei's YouBike commemorative installation unveiled, retired bicycles donated to Indigenous communities** [https://dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=D739A9F6B5C0AB95&sms=72544237BBE4C5F6&s=9B82ECFCBB63CBEC]

臺北市府交通局-新聞稿-臺北市YouBike紀念意象揭幕 退場車輛捐贈原鄉

PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12

1,300 retired 1.0 bicycles donated to Indigenous communities (原鄉), 1,106 transferred to city agencies for neighbourhood patrols and school cycling-safety education, and a memorial marker installed at MRT Taipei City Hall Station Exit 3, the system's first station.

- 9 **Clarification — on unusable, scrapped YouBike 1.0 vehicles** [https://www.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=74806083EBDF5A03&sms=72544237BBE4C5F6&s=1B3B7EC6424DC4D0]

臺北市府全球資訊網-即時新聞澄清-YouBike1.0不堪用報廢車輛說明

PRIMARY Taipei City Government (臺北市府) accessed 2026-08-12

Bicycles judged beyond further use were sold to a recycling contractor in late 2021 at NT\$41 per bike; the city states this reflects disassembly, transport, labour and disposal costs rather than under-pricing. This is a scrap value, not a replacement cost — kept distinct from the unsourced 'NT\$10,000 per bike' figure that had circulated.

- 10 **Public bicycles — introduction** [https://dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=44C34CB5F656CF90&s=2982E80C499FE909]

臺北市府交通局-公共自行車介紹-簡介

PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12

Names 微笑單車股份有限公司 as the operating company under the department's contract, and confirms the citywide 2.0 upgrade completed by end of 2022 alongside 1.0's 3 December 2022 retirement.

- 11 **Press release — Taipei's free first 30 minutes drives a riding boom, cumulative rides about to pass 400 million** [https://dot.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=D739A9F6B5C0AB95&sms=72544237BBE4C5F6&s=3070537DD6D9C528]

臺北市府交通局-新聞稿-臺北市YouBike前30分鐘免費引領騎乘風潮 累計騎乘次數即將突破4億人次

PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12

Dated 14 August 2025 (confirmed via search indexing). States 1,633 stations and 23,860 bikes (including 2,000 e-assist) in Taipei, that 400 million rides took only 17 months to reach after the Feb 2024 fare change versus 2.5 years for the prior 100 million, and a 2026 target of 2,000 stations with 4,500 2.0E bikes.

- 12 **FAQ — why doesn't the YouBike 2.0E electric-assist bike get the first-30-minutes-free or TPASS discounts?** [https://www.gov.taipei/News_Content.aspx?n=EC70A4186D4C828&sms=87415A8B9CE81B16&s=AB88A9B746198352]

臺北市政府交通局-常見問答-電動輔助自行車YouBike2.0E為什麼沒有前30分鐘免費及TPASS都會通定期票優惠？

PRIMARY Taipei City Government, Department of Transportation accessed 2026-08-12

States plainly that YouBike 2.0E does not carry the free-30-minutes or TPASS 臺北北桃1200 discounts in Taipei, with a carve-out for Taipei-issued senior/disability transit cards. Confirms 2.0's fare benefits do not simply extend to 2.0E.

- 13 **From 30 August 2024, YouBike 2.0E goes live in Taipei and New Taipei** [<https://www.youbike.com.tw/region/taipei/news/service/66cbf3b3f2a117dfe7056cf5/>]
2024/08/30起，臺北市及新北市 YouBike 2.0E電輔車正式上線

PRIMARY 微笑單車股份有限公司 (Smile Bike Co., Ltd.) accessed 2026-08-12

The operator's own launch notice: 80–100 km range on a full charge on flat ground, tiered pricing (NT\$20/30min for the first two hours, NT\$40/30min beyond), no subsidy or free period, and shared docks/app with standard 2.0.

- 14 **From 28 February 2024, Taipei YouBike 2.0's first 30 minutes are free** [<https://www.youbike.com.tw/region/taipei/news/service/65dc48e2b507cedede07c6e2/>]
2024/02/28起，臺北市YouBike 2.0 前30分鐘免費

PRIMARY 微笑單車股份有限公司 (Smile Bike Co., Ltd.) accessed 2026-08-12

The operator's own notice of the 2024 fare change: unconditional first 30 minutes free for registered members citywide, then NT\$10/30min to 4 hours, NT\$20/30min to 8 hours, NT\$40/30min beyond.

- 15 **Taipei's free-first-30-minutes YouBike policy takes effect the 28th; bus/MRT transfer discount ends** [<https://www.cna.com.tw/news/aloc/202402270092.aspx>]
北市YouBike前30分鐘免費28日起實施 轉乘公車捷運不再優惠

SECONDARY 中央社 (CNA), 27 February 2024 accessed 2026-08-12

Confirms the transfer discount 「自107年上路」 (began in the 2018 ROC year) and that it was cancelled the same day the unconditional free period began, plus the 1,338→2,000 station and 16,562→27,500 bike 2026 targets as stated by officials at the time.

- 16 Chiang Wan-an restores YouBike's free first 30 minutes, estimated 7,000-tonne annual carbon cut [<https://e-info.org.tw/node/238570>]
蔣萬安恢復YouBike前30分鐘免費 估年減7000噸碳排
SECONDARY 環境資訊中心 (Environmental Information Center), citing Taipei City Government accessed 2026-08-12
States the policy 'restores' (恢復) a free period that predates the transfer discount, names Ko Wen-je's April 2015 cancellation as the prior state, and gives the 15% ridership uplift and 7,000-tonne carbon estimates plus the 2026 fleet/station targets.
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- 17 Historical data feature: free-riding YouBike is back! Why did Ko Wen-je choose to take the criticism and charge NT\$5? [<https://www.storm.mg/article/5033646>]
歷史風數據》免費騎的YouBike回來了！柯文哲當年為何寧願挨罵也要收5元？
SECONDARY 風傳媒 (Storm Media) accessed 2026-08-12
Fetched in full. Confirms the pre-2015 period was completely free, gives the Ko administration's stated commuting/leisure usage-shift rationale for the NT\$5 fee, and states the city's subsidy fell from about NT\$20 million to NT\$8 million a month — a different saving figure from The News Lens's account of the same change.
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- 18 Taipei cancels YouBike's free rides: NT\$5 for the first 30 minutes, New Taipei does not follow [<https://www.thenewslens.com/article/13835>]
北市YouBike免費取消：前30分收5元、新北不跟進
SECONDARY 關鍵評論網 (The News Lens), 2015 accessed 2026-08-12
Fetched in full. Gives the exact effective date, 1 April 2015, and states New Taipei kept its own free first-30-minutes through the end of 2015 while still expanding its network, budgeting roughly NT\$70 million/year to do so — a genuine policy divergence between the two cities, not just a lag.
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- 19 YouBike 1.0 in Taipei bows out 3 December; New Taipei riders forgetting to switch to 2.0 pay an extra NT\$350 [<https://www.businesstoday.com.tw/article/category/183030/post/202211200003/>]
YouBike1.0台北市12/3起退場！新北市騎來忘換YouBike2.0 還車得多付350元
SECONDARY 今周刊 (Business Today), 20 November 2022 accessed 2026-08-12
Source for the NT\$350 cross-boundary misplacement fee for a 1.0 bike ridden from New Taipei into Taipei after Taipei's cutover — no Taipei DOT primary release stating this exact figure was found this run, so it rests on this secondary account alone.
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- 20 YouBike Smile Bike [<https://zh.wikipedia.org/zh-tw/YouBike微笑單車>]
YouBike微笑單車
SECONDARY 維基百科 (Chinese Wikipedia) accessed 2026-08-12
Used only for figures not found in a primary source and flagged as such: the 1.0 unit price (NT\$13,000) and loss fee, the 13,072-bike fleet at 1.0's Taipei retirement, the 2018–19 New Taipei E-YouBike electric-assist trial, and the Putian, China variant built on retired 1.0 docks. None of these four independently verified against a primary source this run.
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- 21 TDX Bike Station City pull [<https://tdx.transportdata.tw/api/basic/v2/Bike/Station/City/{City}>]
交通部運輸資料流通服務平臺 — Bike Station/City

PRIMARY

Ministry of Transportation and Communications TDX / 交通部運輸資料流通服務平臺
accessed 2026-08-23

Build-time pull of the static station feed for Taipei, New Taipei and Taoyuan. Supports the dated station-row counts, published BikesCapacity totals and the fact that live availability is a separate feed.

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Station names, codes and sequence from TDX Transport Data eXchange, Ministry of Transportation and Communications, operators TRTC, NTMC, TYMC, and TMRT. Government open data. Retrieved 2026-08-22; source last updated 2020-01-31. The 12 Sanying station records absent from TDX are sourced directly to New Taipei Metro and government publications on their pages. Provenance.